



This detail taken from an engraving by Paul Revere depicts the British capture of the French fort in Louisbourg, Nova Scotia. The fort was built to protect France's interests in the region and became a target for the British when war was declared in 1756. The town was attacked by land and sea, falling to the British in 1758.

THE SEVEN YEARS' WAR (1756–63) was fought in theaters from India to North America to Europe, making it a truly global conflict. Its roots, however, were European. The earlier **War of Austrian Succession** (see 1740) left many territorial issues unresolved. The **Treaty of Aix-la-Chapelle** (1748) did not settle the dispute between **Prussia** and **Austria** over the province of **Silesia**, located in southeast Prussia and bordering Austria. At the same time, **British** and **French** tensions continued to simmer. Because of complicated

alliances, these situations escalated into what became known as the Seven Years' War.

By 1756, some key incidents had made the battle lines clear. In April, **France invaded Minorca** in the Mediterranean, which Britain had taken from Spain in 1708. The French sent 15,000 troops to the island, where the British had only around 2,500. Britain formally declared war on France. The conflict brought in the **Electorate of Hanover**, in northwest Germany, which was willing to send the British extra troops.

Prussia's **Frederick II** (1712–86), meanwhile, was increasingly suspicious of the alliance between **France and Russia**. In May, his troops entered the **Electorate of**

Men at arms

The sizes of the armies involved in the Seven Years' War are shown here. Although some of the important battles were at sea, most of the fighting was done by army soldiers.



Saxony, between Prussia and Russia. They outnumbered those in Saxony by more than 3:1, but Austria's leader, **Maria Theresa** (1717–80), was quick to send more troops. The war had begun.

Britain and Prussia formed an alliance against France, Russia, Austria, Sweden, Saxony, and eventually Spain. But each country was also pursuing its own interests: Britain wanted France

out of **India** and **North America**; Austria and Prussia both wanted Silesia. Russia wanted to curb Frederick II's growing powers and assist Austria and France.

The European conflict had been preceded by skirmishes in colonial territories: the British and French had been fighting in North America, as well as in India. **Anglo-French tensions** had spilled over into disputes with

local rulers in India, leading to an infamous incident—the **Black Hole of Calcutta**. The **Nawab of Bengal, Siraj-ud-Dawlah** (1733–57), who France supported, attacked the British in Calcutta and imprisoned many of them in a small cell in Fort William. Estimates of the captives range from 60 to 150. Overnight, between 40 and 123 of them died due to overcrowding and heat.



FREDERICK II (1712–86)

Known as "Frederick the Great," the Prussian King Frederick II ruled for 46 years. With his interest in culture and philosophy, Frederick's reign was marked by a liberal spirit. But it was his military prowess that earned Frederick II his reputation, as he transformed the small kingdom of Prussia into a European power.



January 27 Austrian Composer Wolfgang Amadeus Mozart born (d. 1791)

May 15 Britain declares war on France, beginning the Seven Years' War

May 20 Britain loses Minorca to the French

May Frederick II's troops enter Saxony

May 27 Maximilian I Joseph of Bavaria born (d. 1825)

June 20 A large number of British prisoners die in the Black Hole of Calcutta incident

October Thomas Pelham-Holles (1693–1768) resigns as British prime minister after setbacks in the Seven Years' War

December 27 Court-martial of Admiral John Byng (1704–56) begins over his surrender to the French in Minorca